



PTI

INFLAMING PASSIONS
Above, BJP workers protest the communal violence in Murshidabad at a rally in Kolkata, Apr. 13; right, a vehicle set ablaze during anti-Waqf law protests in the district

Kolkata on April 14, asking people to maintain peace. "Why the fight? Why the riots, war, or unrest?" But critics point to the failure of intelligence units and the administration to anticipate the scale of the protests.

The communal unrest led to the exodus of some 400 terrified people. The BJP claims around 80 Hindu families fled across the Bhagirathi river to Parlalpur in Malda, though local officials dispute the number. There are also allegations that the BJP may have orchestrated the exodus, in a bid to create a communal narrative. Nor was the violence one-sided—Muslim homes faced retaliatory attacks, too. The BJP has also been accused of circulating doctored images of the violence to whip up emotions.

Investigators suspect that the Social Democratic Party of India (SDPI), an offshoot of the banned Popular Front of India, played a role in fuelling the unrest. CPI(M) leader Mohammed Salim visited the family of Hargobindo and Chandan—both party supporters—and condemned the state's inaction against the alleged hate speeches by BJP leaders. "The hate speeches led to reaction by the other community. It appears that these speeches also serve the ruling dispensation some purpose," he said.

TMC spokesperson Kunal Ghosh hinted at a larger conspiracy involving "some central agencies, a section of the